

U.S. Census Bureau News

U.S. Department of Commerce • Washington, D.C. 20233

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2012, AT 8:30 A.M. EST

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CB12-25

ADVANCE MONTHLY SALES FOR RETAIL AND FOOD SERVICES JANUARY 2012

Intention to Revise Retail Estimates: Monthly retail sales estimates will be revised based on the results of the 2010 Annual Retail Trade Survey. Revised not adjusted estimates and corresponding adjusted estimates are scheduled for release on April 30, 2012.

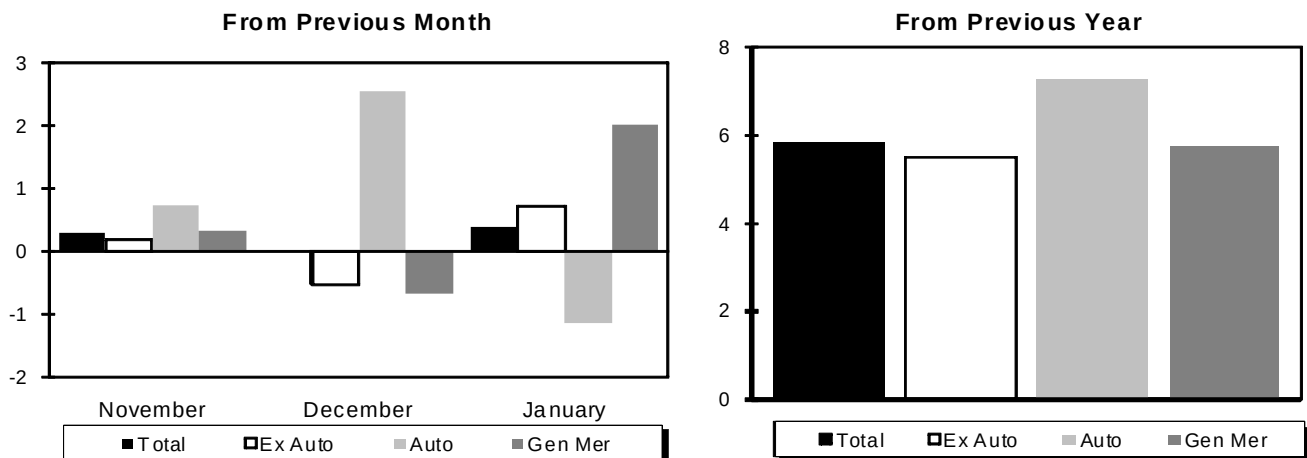
The U.S. Census Bureau announced today that advance estimates of U.S. retail and food services sales for January, adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences, but not for price changes, were \$401.4 billion, an increase of 0.4 percent ($\pm 0.5\%$)* from the previous month and 5.8 percent ($\pm 0.7\%$) above January 2011. Total sales for the November 2011 through January 2012 period were up 6.3 percent ($\pm 0.5\%$) from the same period a year ago. The November to December 2011 percent change was revised from 0.1 percent ($\pm 0.5\%$)* to virtually unchanged ($\pm 0.3\%$)*.

Retail trade sales were up 0.4 percent ($\pm 0.5\%$)* from December 2011 and 5.5 percent ($\pm 0.7\%$) above last year. Food services and drinking places sales were up 8.2 percent ($\pm 1.8\%$) from January 2011 and building material and garden equipment and supplies dealers were up 8.1 percent ($\pm 2.6\%$) from last year.

The advance estimates are based on a subsample of the Census Bureau's full retail and food services sample. A stratified random sampling method is used to select approximately 5,000 retail and food services firms whose sales are then weighted and benchmarked to represent the complete universe of over three million retail and food services firms. Responding firms account for approximately 65% of the MARTS dollar volume estimate. For an explanation of the measures of sampling variability included in this report, please see the Reliability of Estimates section on the last page of this publication.

Percent Change in Retail and Food Services Sales

(Estimates adjusted for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences, but not for price changes)



The Advance Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services for February is scheduled to be released March 13, 2012 at 8:30 a.m. EDT.

For customized retail time series estimates by industry, visit the Census Bureau's web site at <www.census.gov/timeseries>. For additional survey information, visit <www.census.gov/retail>.

* The 90 percent confidence interval includes zero. The Census Bureau does not have sufficient statistical evidence to conclude that the actual change is different than zero.

Table 1. Estimated Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Total sales estimates are shown in millions of dollars and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS ¹ code	Kind of Business	Not Adjusted							Adjusted ²				
		1 Month Total		2012	2011			2010	2012	2011			2010
		2012	% Chg. 2011	Jan. ³ (a)	Dec. (p)	Nov. (r)	Jan.	Dec.	Jan. ³ (a)	Dec. (p)	Nov. (r)	Jan. (r)	Dec. (r)
	Retail & food services,												
	total	361,351	5.6	361,351	459,829	398,441	342,082	434,288	401,400	399,869	399,796	379,332	376,487
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ...	298,488	5.2	298,488	388,898	334,474	283,857	369,616	329,732	327,370	329,089	312,509	310,561
	Retail	321,887	5.4	321,887	416,793	358,687	305,284	394,780	358,782	357,511	357,594	339,934	337,018
	GAFO⁴	(*)	(*)	(*)	143,376	107,724	81,938	138,743	(*)	98,532	99,128	94,936	95,287
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	62,863	8.0	62,863	70,931	63,967	58,225	64,672	71,668	72,499	70,707	66,823	65,926
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers .	56,914	8.2	56,914	64,436	57,263	52,619	58,278	64,822	65,684	63,838	60,274	59,286
44111	New car dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	55,409	48,527	43,755	49,626	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4413	Auto parts, acc. & tire stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	6,495	6,704	5,606	6,394	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	6,908	7.9	6,908	9,398	8,216	6,402	8,762	7,771	7,786	7,643	7,209	7,277
4421	Furniture stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	4,418	4,228	3,630	4,120	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4422	Home furnishings stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	4,980	3,988	2,772	4,642	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
443	Electronics & appliance stores	7,537	-1.1	7,537	12,837	9,980	7,618	13,126	8,228	8,187	8,631	8,276	8,321
44311, 13	Appl., T.V. & camera.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	9,941	7,554	5,920	10,190	(*)	6,320	6,490	6,428	6,433
44312	Computer & software stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	2,896	2,426	1,698	2,936	(*)	1,867	2,141	1,848	1,888
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	19,480	10.5	19,480	23,439	24,660	17,625	22,339	26,054	25,999	25,479	24,099	24,533
4441	Building mat. & sup. dealers	(*)	(*)	(*)	18,963	20,294	14,828	18,306	(*)	20,884	20,540	19,358	19,876
445	Food & beverage stores.....	50,294	3.0	50,294	56,607	51,836	48,825	53,986	52,228	51,578	51,886	50,058	49,453
4451	Grocery stores	45,833	2.9	45,833	49,072	46,327	44,538	46,889	46,768	46,164	46,466	44,852	44,319
4453	Beer, wine & liquor stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	5,073	3,796	2,973	4,772	(*)	3,689	3,736	3,586	3,504
446	Health & personal care stores	22,651	1.0	22,651	25,652	22,669	22,426	25,129	23,066	23,131	23,061	22,977	22,517
44611	Pharmacies & drug stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	21,055	18,995	19,026	20,910	(*)	19,246	19,245	19,199	18,940
447	Gasoline stations	40,991	7.3	40,991	42,390	42,829	38,216	39,434	44,946	44,341	45,514	41,858	41,292
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	14,127	3.4	14,127	30,784	20,758	13,669	28,586	19,183	19,181	19,077	18,220	18,083
44811	Men's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	1,156	761	524	1,057	(*)	(S)	(S)	(S)	(S)
44812	Women's clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	4,620	3,456	2,266	4,442	(*)	3,224	3,194	3,058	3,133
44814	Family clothing stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	12,081	8,619	5,227	11,409	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4482	Shoe stores	(*)	(*)	(*)	3,216	2,338	1,687	2,981	(*)	2,356	2,340	2,220	2,223
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book & music stores.....	7,010	3.5	7,010	12,062	7,842	6,770	11,890	7,473	7,395	7,440	7,164	7,263
452	General merchandise stores.....	46,919	4.7	46,919	74,201	57,901	44,805	72,404	54,041	52,976	53,333	51,093	51,454
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.).....	11,933	-0.6	11,933	26,448	18,087	12,008	26,784	15,417	15,271	15,294	15,183	15,389
4521	Department stores (incl. L.D.) ⁵	(*)	(*)	(*)	26,913	18,439	12,148	27,161	(*)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)	(NA)
4529	Other general merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	47,753	39,814	32,797	45,620	(*)	37,705	38,039	35,910	36,065
45291	Warehouse clubs & supercenters.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	41,104	34,613	29,143	39,488	(*)	32,883	33,250	31,438	31,641
45299	All oth. gen. merch. stores.....	(*)	(*)	(*)	6,649	5,201	3,654	6,132	(*)	4,822	4,789	4,472	4,424
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	8,497	3.7	8,497	11,654	10,134	8,190	11,240	10,099	10,048	10,273	9,722	9,660
454	Nonstore retailers	34,610	6.4	34,610	46,838	37,895	32,513	43,212	34,025	34,390	34,550	32,435	31,239
4541	Elect. shopping & m/o houses	(*)	(*)	(*)	37,741	29,378	23,156	34,016	(*)	26,559	26,254	24,634	23,721
722	Food services & drinking places ...	39,464	7.2	39,464	43,036	39,754	36,798	39,508	42,618	42,358	42,202	39,398	39,469

(*) Advance estimates are not available for this kind of business.

(NA) Not available (S) Suppressed (a) Advance estimate (p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(1) For a full description of the NAICS codes used in this table, see <http://www.census.gov/eos/www/naics>

(2) Estimates are concurrently adjusted for seasonal variation and for holiday and trading day differences, but not for price changes. Concurrent seasonal adjustment uses all available unadjusted estimates as input to the X-12 ARIMA program. The factors derived from the program are used in calculating all seasonally adjusted estimates shown in this table. Year-to-date seasonally adjusted sales estimates are not tabulated. Adjustment factors and explanatory material can be found on the Internet at <http://www.census.gov/retail>

(3) Advance estimates are based on early reports obtained from a small sample of firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey (MRTS) sample. All other estimates are from the MRTS sample

(4) GAFO represents firms which specialize in department store types of merchandise and is comprised of furniture & home furnishings (442), electronics & appliances (443), clothing & accessories (448), sporting goods, hobby, book, and music (451), general merchandise (452), office supply, stationery, and gift stores (4532).

(5) Estimates include data for leased departments operated within department stores. Data for this line are not included in broader kind-of-business totals.

Note: Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <http://www.census.gov/retail>

Table 2. Estimated Change in Monthly Sales for Retail and Food Services, by Kind of Business

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey, Monthly Retail Trade Survey, and administrative records.)

NAICS code	Kind of Business	Percent Change ¹					
		Jan. 2012 Advance from --		Dec. 2011 Preliminary from --		Nov. 2011 through Jan. 2012 from --	
		Dec. 2011 (p)	Jan. 2011 (r)	Nov. 2011 (r)	Dec. 2010 (r)	Aug. 2011 through Oct. 2011	Nov. 2010 through Jan. 2011
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.4	5.8	0.0	6.2	1.3	6.3
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts)	0.7	5.5	-0.5	5.4	0.6	5.9
	Retail	0.4	5.5	0.0	6.1	1.2	6.2
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	-1.1	7.3	2.5	10.0	4.4	8.4
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers	-1.3	7.5	2.9	10.8	5.0	9.0
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	-0.2	7.8	1.9	7.0	2.4	6.5
443	Electronics & appliance stores	0.5	-0.6	-5.1	-1.6	-1.4	0.5
444	Building material & garden eq. & supplies dealers.....	0.2	8.1	2.0	6.0	1.4	6.4
445	Food & beverage stores.....	1.3	4.3	-0.6	4.3	0.2	4.4
4451	Grocery stores	1.3	4.3	-0.6	4.2	0.1	4.4
446	Health & personal care stores	-0.3	0.4	0.3	2.7	-0.1	1.9
447	Gasoline stations	1.4	7.4	-2.6	7.4	-0.4	9.7
448	Clothing & clothing accessories stores	0.0	5.3	0.5	6.1	0.7	5.0
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book & music stores.....	1.1	4.3	-0.6	1.8	-1.3	2.9
452	General merchandise stores.....	2.0	5.8	-0.7	3.0	0.7	3.9
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.).....	1.0	1.5	-0.2	-0.8	0.0	-0.9
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	0.5	3.9	-2.2	4.0	-1.7	5.0
454	Nonstore retailers	-1.1	4.9	-0.5	10.1	2.3	9.3
722	Food services & drinking places	0.6	8.2	0.4	7.3	1.7	7.6

(p) Preliminary estimate (r) Revised estimate

(1) Estimates shown in this table are derived from adjusted estimates provided in Table 1 of this report.

Note: Table 3 provides estimated measures of sampling variability. Additional information on confidentiality protection, sampling error, nonsampling error, sample design, and definitions may be found at <http://www.census.gov/retail>.

Source: U.S. Census Bureau

Survey Description

The U.S. Census Bureau conducts the Advance Monthly Retail Trade and Food Services Survey (MARTS) to provide an early estimate of monthly sales by kind of business for retail and food service firms located in the United States. Each month, questionnaires are mailed to a probability sample of approximately 5,000 employer firms selected from the larger Monthly Retail Trade Survey (MRTS). Firms responding to MARTS account for approximately 65% of the total national sales estimate. Advance sales estimates are computed using a link relative estimator. The change in sales from the previous month is estimated using only units that have reported data for both the current and

previous month. There is no imputation or adjustment for nonrespondents in MARTS. The total sales estimate is derived by multiplying this ratio by the preliminary sales estimate for the previous month (derived from the larger MRTS sample). Detailed industry estimates are summed to derive total estimates at broad industry levels. The monthly estimates are adjusted using annual survey estimates and for seasonal variation and holiday and trading-day differences. Additional information on MARTS and MRTS can be found on the Census Bureau website at: <http://www.census.gov/retail>.

Official Business

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Reliability of Estimates

Because the estimates presented in this report are based on a sample survey, they contain sampling error and nonsampling error.

Sampling error is the difference between the estimate and the result that would be obtained from a complete enumeration of the sampling frame conducted under the same survey conditions. This error occurs because only a subset of the entire sampling frame is measured in a sample survey. Standard errors and coefficients of variation (CV), as given in Table 3 of this report, are estimated measures of sampling variation.

The margin of sampling error, as used on page 1, gives a range about the estimate which is a 90 percent confidence interval. If, for example, the percent change estimate is +1.2 percent and its estimated standard error is 0.9 percent, then the margin of sampling error is $\pm 1.65 \times 0.9$ percent or ± 1.5 percent, and the 90 percent confidence interval is -0.3 percent to +2.7 percent. If the interval contains 0, then one does not have sufficient evidence to conclude at the 90 percent

confidence level that the change is different from zero and therefore the change is not statistically significant. Estimated changes shown in the text are statistically significant unless otherwise noted. For a monthly total, the median estimated coefficient of variation is given. The resulting confidence interval is the estimated value $\pm 1.65 \times CV \times$ (the estimated monthly total). The Census Bureau recommends that individuals using estimates in this report incorporate this information into their analyses, as sampling error could affect the conclusions drawn from the estimates.

Nonsampling error encompasses all other factors that contribute to the total error of a sample survey estimate. This type of error can occur because of nonresponse, insufficient coverage of the universe of retail businesses, mistakes in the recording and coding of data, and other errors of collection, response, coverage, or processing. Although nonsampling error is not measured directly, the Census Bureau employs quality control procedures throughout the process to minimize this type of error.

Table 3. Estimated Measures of Sampling Variability and Revision to Advance Estimates Jan. 2012

(Estimates are shown as percents and are based on data from the Advance Monthly Retail Trade Survey and Monthly Retail Trade Survey)

NAICS Code	Kind of Business	Median CV ⁽¹⁾ for Current Mo. (%)	Median standard error ⁽¹⁾ for Percent change			Revision for month- to-month change ⁽²⁾	
			Previous Mo. to Current Mo.	Previous Qtr. to Current Qtr.	Current Mo. to same Mo. Last Yr.	Average revision	Median absolute revision
	Retail & food services,						
	total	0.7	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.1	0.2
	Total (excl. motor vehicle & parts) ..	0.7	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.1	0.2
	Retail	0.8	0.3	0.2	0.4	0.1	0.1
441	Motor vehicle & parts dealers	2.4	1.0	0.5	1.3	0.2	0.6
4411, 4412	Auto & other motor veh. dealers .	2.5	1.1	0.6	1.5	0.2	0.7
442	Furniture & home furn. stores	3.1	1.5	0.8	1.7	0.2	0.4
443	Electronics & appliance stores	1.5	0.6	0.4	0.9	-0.2	0.4
444	Building material & garden eq. & ...						
	supplies dealers	3.5	1.7	1.1	1.6	0.1	0.4
445	Food & beverage stores	1.2	0.2	0.2	0.4	0.0	0.1
4451	Grocery stores	1.3	0.2	0.2	0.5	0.0	0.2
446	Health & personal care stores	1.8	0.4	0.3	1.1	0.0	0.3
447	Gasoline stations	2.4	0.5	0.4	1.0	0.0	0.7
448	Clothing & clothing accessories						
	stores	2.7	0.7	0.6	0.9	0.2	0.3
451	Sporting goods, hobby, book &						
	music stores	4.0	1.9	1.3	2.2	0.2	0.9
452	General merchandise stores	0.3	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1	0.1
4521	Department stores (ex. L.D.)	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.1
453	Miscellaneous store retailers	4.0	2.4	1.3	3.0	0.1	0.9
454	Nonstore retailers	2.2	1.0	0.8	1.5	0.2	0.4
722	Food services & drinking places ..	2.0	0.9	0.6	1.1	0.2	0.3

(1) Estimated measures of sampling variability are based on estimates not adjusted for seasonal variation or holiday or trading-day differences. Medians are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.

(2) These columns provide measures of the difference between the advance-to-preliminary and preliminary-to-final estimates of month-to-month change for the same pair of months as measured by the Advance sample and MRTS sample. The average and median revisions are based on estimates for the most recent 12 months.